In 1927, Ambedkar marched with ‘untouchables’ in the town of Mahad, Maharashtra, and drank water from a tank they had been denied access to by upper-caste Hindus. The latter, believing the water was now polluted, conducted a purification ritual that involved the addition of curd, cow dung, cow urine and milk to the water.

The Hindu Code Bill

Ambedkar’s other major project was the controversial Hindu Code Bill, which sought to create laws that would give Hindu women the same rights as Hindu men. Conservative Hindu groups, such as the Hindu Mahasabha, and members of the Congress like Rajendra Prasad opposed the bill. When even a watered-down version couldn’t be passed, Ambedkar resigned as law minister in 1951. The bill was eventually split into parts, debated and passed between 1952 and 1956, although some of its original provisions were diluted. However, the fact that it was possible at all was due to Ambedkar’s unwavering commitment to equality.



Ambedkar died in 1956 at the age of sixty-six, having made enormous contributions to both his community and country in his lifetime. His life and work continue to inspire contemporary anti-caste movements.